

The Official Top Ten

Yesterday's fat-cat can be today's mouse. Today's state satrap is tomorrow's kingmaker. Hierarchy continues to be sabotaged by political power.

By Dilip Bobb

Power, as someone famously said, flows from the barrel of a gun. In India, it flows from the barrels of the sub-machine guns carried by the commandos who provide security to our politicians. The larger the number of commandos, the greater the power, or so logic would demand. Except it's all a matter of perception; threat perception and public perception. In today's coalition politics, the trappings of power mean little, when the leaders of smaller parties can dictate the shape and formation of the next government. Power today is more ephemeral and transient than ever before. Yesterday's political fat-cat can become tomorrow's mouse that roared in alarmingly quick time. For much of last year, the Left was the tail that wagged the UPA dog. The Indo-US nuclear deal changed that equation and with it the clout that the comrades and its leader Prakash Karat wielded.

Going by official protocol, the prime minister would head the official power list, closely followed by his senior cabinet colleagues. Alas, occupancy of Lutyen's sprawling bungalows no longer offers automatic access to the levers of power. State satraps and regional chieftains are increasingly the ones who exercise influence, way beyond the borders of the state or region they get their votes from. That has also meant that even the prime minister is perceived as less powerful than the leader of the party he represents. Similarly, the deal-makers and go-betweens are in ascendancy as the national parties scramble to put together a winnable coalition. For decades, power was concentrated in the hands of a few; of late, it has sprouted multiple heads. The changing face, or faces, of Indian politics means that power is more democratic and largely based on changes in public perception. A chief minister labelled a communal monster not so long ago today tops the popularity charts for his development agenda. Elsewhere, shrewd caste calculations allow another chief minister to dominate the national political space. They represent the new power centres and that is the criterion which governs the official rankings on the following pages.

SONIA
GANDHI

1

62, Congress President (1)

The Supreme Hand

Because she is the most powerful player in the world's biggest democracy and it is she who runs the Government, as was obvious when the Cabinet announced a fuel price cut two days after she hinted at it during a Rae Bareilly rally in January. **Because** she is still the Congress party's favourite prime ministerial candidate despite consistently refusing the job and even though she does not hold a ministerial portfolio, her picture appears along with the prime minister in Government of India advertisements.

the slip From No. 6 to No. 21 in the *Forbes* List of Most Powerful Women in the world in 2008.

favourite governance tool The garb of consensus. Takes a decision, then has lengthy meetings with party leaders and Cabinet ministers who end up endorsing what she has already decided.

should be embarrassed about Not asking a single question in Parliament in the last five years and not participating in a single debate this year.

leisure time Loves reading. She has just completed *Unaccustomed Earth* by Jhumpa Lahiri, *My Name is Salma* by Fadia Faqir and *Charlie Wilson's War* by George Crile. Sundays are for her two grandchildren.

USP She is the only woman who has been the daughter-in-law of a prime minister, the wife of a prime minister, the boss of a prime minister and in all probability, will one day be the mother of a prime minister.